Henry the Younger's amicable relationship with his father in 1175. Rather, Richard and Philip had identified with each other. Their cause was the same: both of them wanted Richard to inherit the throne of England.

After Henry the Younger's death, Henry II had not settled on one of his surviving sons as heir. Geoffrey had died in 1186, accidentally killed at a jousting tournament. Richard, the natural choice, was still fiercely loyal to Eleanor and hostile to his father; Henry had not forgotten Richard's long holdout in Poitiers, back in 1174. John, on the other hand, had been young enough during that earlier rebellion to escape full blame and seemed to be rising in Henry's estimation. Henry had already named him Lord of Ireland, intending to give him the kingship of the Irish lands.

Richard, watching his father shower John with favors, could see his throne slipping away. So could Philip II, who wanted the Western Frankish lands bordering his own governed by a sympathetic king of England, not a mere duke subject to a younger brother's decrees.

In the fall of 1188, Philip and Richard together summoned Henry to a conference at Bonsmoulins, on the eastern edge of Normandy. There they demanded that the king name Richard his heir and require the barons of England to swear loyalty to him at once.

Henry II refused. Now aged fifty-six, he had spent thirty-five years ruling both England and his family, rejecting all attempts to block his will, demolishing opposition, ignoring threats. He would not be bullied by his own son and Louis's stripling successor.

According to onlookers, the conversation began to degenerate into shouts; and then, to drawn swords. No one struck, though. Instead, Richard turned his back on his father and went on his knees to Philip II, swearing homage to the king of France in place of his father.

That night, Henry sent the English knight William Marshal after Richard, hoping to persuade his son to return to England. But Richard had already left his quarters and could not be found. Marshal did make a new discovery: The night before, Richard had sent out perhaps two hundred letters. He was already raising his supporters to fight; he had never intended to make peace with his father.[3]

Henry returned to England and, entirely abandoning his plans for crusade, began to prepare for all-out war instead. But over Christmas he began to grow ill. Contemporary chroniclers mention a fever, arthritis, and a fistula: most likely an abscessed anal gland, in itself miserable but not fatal, which eventually escalated into a septic infection and attacked the king's joints. Over the next seven months, Henry became progressively sicker, even while he tried to prosecute the war against his son. Philip and Richard, aggressively